



BEFORE

In 1792 France was declared a Republic << 302–03. The change in government occurred during a series of wars in Europe and beyond.

REVOLUTIONARY WARS

The French Revolutionary Wars (1792–1802) were initially fought to protect French borders from other European powers.

However, they

brought in their wake a **citizen's army** inspired by revolutionary principles, an aggressive foreign policy, and a war economy dependent on forced enlistment, conquest, and loot, all of which facilitated Napoleon Bonaparte's rise to power << 304–05.

RISE OF NAPOLEON

Having been tainted by association with the Jacobins after Robespierre's fall, Napoleon redeemed himself in October 1795 by crushing the last popular revolt in Paris, and then by conducting a **brilliant military campaign** in Italy—he was welcomed as a hero on his return to Paris in 1797. Following a highly popular but less successful campaign into Egypt, he returned to Paris in 1799 to seize power through a **military coup**.

Once in power, Napoleon behaved like an enlightened despot (see pp.270–71). He banned democracy, and set up a network of police spies responsible for censorship and for arresting his political opponents.

Following an assassination attempt in 1800, Napoleon was able to harness widespread support for his own dynastic ambitions, to fend off any attempt to restore the Bourbons—the royal family that had ruled France between 1589 and 1792—and to establish himself as the French leader. In 1804 Napoleon crowned himself “first Emperor of the French,” in a ceremony overseen by the Pope, thereby sanctifying his position.

The building of an empire

Between 1805 and 1815, Napoleon's armies took on seven different coalition armies made up of various European

powers. He won his most notable victories in 1805 at Austerlitz in the modern Czech Republic against the Austrians and Russians; in 1806 at Jena in Germany against the Prussians; and in 1807 at Friedland against the Russians, in their own country, forcing them to sue for peace. In 1812, at the height of his power, France's rule comprised 130 administrative regions.

Napoleon's ambitions outside Europe were more low-key. In 1803, he abandoned France's claims to the Americas by selling Louisiana to the US for \$15 million (see pp.310–11). In the French West Indies, sugar plantations were disrupted by slave revolts and foreign invasion, although Saint-Domingue (now Haiti) was the only one to gain its independence in 1804.

Napoleon's empire grew in two stages: 1800–07 and 1807–12. During the first stage, he incorporated the Low Countries (the Netherlands and

Belgium), northern Italy (Piedmont), and western Germany under his rule, emulating Charlemagne's achievements of 1,000 years earlier (see pp.188–89). In 1806, the Confederation of the Rhine unified the small German states, such as Bavaria and Saxony, into kingdoms allied to France. French legislation, such as the Napoleonic Code, took root in this “Inner Empire.”

After 1807, his conquests included southern Italy, Spain, northern Germany, Illyria (the southern Balkans), and the Duchy of Warsaw (Poland). Charles Talleyrand, Napoleon's scheming foreign advisor, warned against extra expansion during this period, and these regions often

The Battle of Trafalgar

On October 21, 1805, the English Admiral Horatio Nelson sank 22 French and Spanish ships in the pivotal sea battle of the Napoleonic wars, sealing Britain's naval supremacy for the next 100 years.

The Napoleonic Wars

Between 1805 and 1815, Napoleon's armies conquered most of western Europe in a series of notable victories, creating an empire with 44 million French subjects. However, his plans to invade England were thwarted by naval defeat at Trafalgar, and his obsession with conquest led to a disastrous campaign in Russia. Napoleon was finally brought down at Waterloo in 1815.

